

CASE ID: 198912710220

EPISODE NAME: China Threatens France Over Arms Sales to Taiwan 1989

1989/12/28 - 1990/01/11

Sender: China (710)

Target: France (220)

Issue: End Weapons/Materials Proliferation (9)

Final Outcome: Complete Acquiescence by Target to threat (2)

Summary:

On 1989/12/28, China condemned France in response to rumors that the French were planning to sell 16 Lafayette frigates to Taiwan.¹ France pulled out of the sale under pressure from China on 1990/01/11.²

Narrative:

On 1989/12/28, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesman Jin Guihua issued a vague threat towards France that China was, “resolutely opposed to any country selling any kind of weapons and military equipment to Taiwan.”³ The spokesman was responding to rumors that the French and Taiwanese governments were close to a deal in which the French national shipping company DCN would sell 16 Lafayette frigates to the island, each costing around \$300 million USD.⁴

The French government approved the sale on 1990/01/03, bringing it much closer to a final decision, despite the warning from Beijing.⁵ It was the largest military deal between France and Taiwan at the time.⁶ Shortly after this, China threatened to sever relations with France.⁷ Under

¹ “France May Sell Frigates to Taiwan.” *South China Morning Post*, December 30th, 1989.

<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1540507138/526B7CABA9CA45A5PQ/4?accountid=14556&sourcetype=News papers>.

² Chen, David. “Beijing Victory as Frigates Cancelled.” *South China Morning Post*, January 12th, 1989.

<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1540515036/526B7CABA9CA45A5PQ/5?accountid=14556&sourcetype=News papers>.

³ “France May Sell Frigates to Taiwan.” *South China Morning Post*, December 30th, 1989.

<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1540507138/526B7CABA9CA45A5PQ/4?accountid=14556&sourcetype=News papers>.

⁴ Ibid.

⁵ “Paris frigate deal reported off.” *South China Morning Post*, January 11th, 1990.

<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1540514330/526B7CABA9CA45A5PQ/6?accountid=14556&sourcetype=News papers>.

⁶ “France May Sell Frigates to Taiwan.” *South China Morning Post*, December 30th, 1989.

<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1540507138/526B7CABA9CA45A5PQ/4?accountid=14556&sourcetype=News papers>.

⁷ Chen, David. “Beijing Victory as Frigates Cancelled.” *South China Morning Post*, January 12th, 1989.

<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1540515036/526B7CABA9CA45A5PQ/5?accountid=14556&sourcetype=News papers>.

pressure, France officially backed down from the sale on 1990/01/11.⁸ China reportedly considered France's about-face a diplomatic victory.⁹

France would eventually sell six frigates¹⁰ and 60 Mirage fighter jets¹¹ to Taiwan in 1991/09 and 1992/12 respectively. The sales caused a rupture in relations between the two countries that lasted until 1994/01/12.¹²

⁸ "Paris frigate deal reported off." *South China Morning Post*, January 11th, 1990.

<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1540514330/526B7CABA9CA45A5PQ/6?accountid=14556&sourcetype=News papers>.

⁹ Chen, David. "Beijing Victory as Frigates Cancelled." *South China Morning Post*, January 12th, 1989.

<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1540515036/526B7CABA9CA45A5PQ/5?accountid=14556&sourcetype=News papers>.

¹⁰ "Taiwan signs contract for six French light frigates." *South China Morning Post*, September 6th, 1991.

<https://www.proquest.com/docview/1541007690/7F5F3B4141B1497DPQ/1?accountid=14556&sourcetype=News papers>.

¹¹ Nicholas D. Kristof. "CHINA SAYS FRANCE MUST CLOSE OFFICE." *The New York Times*, December 24th, 1992. <https://www.nytimes.com/1992/12/24/world/china-says-france-must-close-office.html>.

¹² Cohen, Roger. "France Bars Taiwan Sales, Warming China Ties." *The New York Times*, 13 Jan. 1994. <https://www.nytimes.com/1994/01/13/world/france-bars-taiwan-sales-warming-china-ties.html>.